

Question:

A mental health volunteer is interviewing locals as part of a community outreach program. A 46-year-old man discloses that he has felt sad for as long as he can remember. He feels as though his life is cursed and if something terrible can happen to him, it usually will. He has difficulty making decisions and feels hopeless. He also feels that he has had worsening suicidal ideations, guilt from past problems, energy, and concentration over the past 2 weeks. He is otherwise getting enough sleep and able to hold a job. Which of the following statement best describes this patient's condition?

Answer Choices:

- A. The patient is at risk for double depression.
- B. The patient may have symptoms of mania or psychosis.
- C. The patient is likely to show anhedonia.
- D. The patient likely has paranoid personality disorder.

Reasoning + Answer:

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Finding Reasoning Paths :

- 1 . Persistent sadness -> Major Depressive Disorder (MDD) -> Anhedonia .
- 2 . Hopelessness -> Major Depressive Disorder (MDD) -> Anhedonia .
- 3 . Suicidal ideation -> Major Depressive Disorder (MDD) -> Anhedonia .
- 4 . Chronic sadness -> Persistent Depressive Disorder (dysthymia) -> Anhedonia .
- 5 . Chronic sadness -> Adjustment Disorder with Depressed Mood -> Anhedonia .

Reasoning Process :

- 1 . **Persistent sadness**: The patient reports feeling sad for as long as he can remember and describes his life as being "curse-cursed." This chronicity of sadness is a hallmark feature of persistent depressive disorders , such as dysthymia , or major depressive disorder (MDD). However , the presence of additional symptoms (e.g ., hopelessness , suicidal ideation , difficulty making decisions , energy , and concentration deficits) suggests that MDD is more likely than dysthymia alone .
- 2 . **Hopelessness and depressive symptoms**: Hopelessness is a negative affect that is commonly seen in major depressive disorder . The patient’s feeling of being trapped and unable to improve his situation further supports this diagnosis .
- 3 . **Suicidal ideation**: Suicidal ideation is a severe symptom that is often associated with major depressive disorder . While it could also occur in other conditions (e.g ., bipolar disorder , psychosis), the absence of other manic or psychotic symptoms makes MDD the most likely diagnosis .
- 4 . **Difficulty making decisions and energy /cognitive impairment**: These symptoms align with major depressive disorder , which often involves diminished motivation , executive functioning deficits , and fatigue .
- 5 . **Exclusion of other conditions**:
 - **Schizophrenia**: There is no evidence of hallucinations , delusions , or disorganized thinking to suggest psychosis .
 - **Bipolar disorder**: While suicidal ideation can occur in bipolar disorder , there is no mention of manic or hypomanic episodes .
 - **Adjustment disorder**: The chronic nature of the symptoms (lasting as long as he can remember) makes this less likely .
 - **Other medical or neurological conditions**: The symptoms do not suggest a secondary cause (e.g ., medication-induced depression , vitamin deficiencies , or other medical conditions).
- 6 . **Anhedonia**: Anhedonia , the inability to experience pleasure , is a core feature of major depressive disorder . While persistent sadness alone is not anhedonia , the presence of other depressive symptoms strongly supports this diagnosis .

Conclusion :

The patient is most likely experiencing major depressive disorder with anhedonia . This conclusion is supported by the chronicity of sadness , hopelessness , suicidal ideation , difficulty making decisions , energy deficits , and cognitive impairment , which are all consistent with MDD . Anhedonia is a key symptom of MDD and aligns with the patient’s presentation .

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The patient is likely to show anhedonia .

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